

A loose collection of the Cardinal Rule of Relationships

Whoever needs the other less has all the power



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The person who needs the other person the least holds the most power

Rollo Tomassi

Choosing to let small things go or choosing connection and love over being right

I.

Another argument. It might make sense, it might not, but you're in another argument. You're in a dead bedroom, or a dying one. You think about sex the way a starving man thinks about a sandwich, and the only response is to shame you for daring to be hungry. I don't know the statistics, and wouldn't trust them if I saw them anyways. Too many people with too heavy a bias and too much money surrounding clever and engaging lies or omissions. It doesn't matter if every married man is in this sad sack state, or half, or barely any. If you're in that position, the only statistic that matters is you.

You're not alone. If you were, I wouldn't have millions of words from thousands of men on this very issue. Some were there for a while and found a way out. Some men have never left. Some men know nothing else. Like a choir of men singing out of tune, all the tunes converge on a song that sounds right for the ear. It's the cardinal rule of relationships: whoever needs the other person less has the power in that relationship. It doesn't matter that you married her, created a covenant in the eyes of the lord. It doesn't matter that you signed paperwork to achieve the lifelong legal status on your tax forms. It doesn't matter that a lifetime of television, film and literature has told you what your responsibilities and benefits are. We are all cavemen with cell phones and our biology drives this adversarial game of sex and commitment. It works great when you're a caveman in a small knit community. It doesn't work as well when you're a Director in a Fortune 500 company. And so you have another argument that you loaded the dishwasher slightly wrong, or that the sexy times that you scheduled last week after your amazing birthday present is ruined because of the smallest slight that you had

ten minutes ago. It's Three Card Monty, and you can't seem to get the Queen of Hearts, no matter how closely you watch the shuffle.

If you're in a dead or lacking bedroom, you don't have the power to survive an argument. Your woman is telling you that they don't find you attractive as you do them. She can't articulate it as she doesn't know this either, or doesn't want to believe it. She has the same gaslighting you do, so when she knows how to be a good wife but doesn't feel like it she looks for proxies. It's not attraction, it's not desire, it's got to be the spoons facing the wrong direction. And she believes it.

She has to. She's predisposed to. Back in the caveman days men had the power to crush a woman with a rock if she got stingy, so they became very good liars. Guys aren't stupid and catch on, eventually. So the arms race between smart men noticing bullshit and cunning women building better bullshit has been our modus operandi for the last couple hundred thousand years, or six thousand, depending on where you spend your Sundays.

Go Raiders.

She doesn't think of you as often, or desire you as much. She has less respect for you than you do her. Technically, women don't have respect, they have desire, but you can't tell the difference, which is part of the problem. Women hold the power in the relationship. They are more willing to walk away and have nagged the system to enable that freedom just as much as you want to pretend the freedom shouldn't exist. This is where the Men's Rights Advocates, or the sexless and frustrated start grabbing charts and statistics. They are missing the point. The queen of hearts was never there, the dealer palmed the card 20 seconds ago and is just fleecing you. Stop playing a rigged game. Or do, I don't suffer one way or the other.

By wanting her more than she wants you, you will impact everything in your relationship. She's less willing to listen, compromise, or defer. She

is less appreciative. Anything you do will be seen as pandering, and anything you don't do will be seen as deficient.

"You know if you helped more around the house I'd be more comfortable and maybe put out more." Too bad the places are supposed to be in the back of the rack and not the front. You ruined it.

She has a shorter fuse. She has higher standards. She's less interested in intimacy and brings less to the bedroom. Expectations are up and standards are down. She developed a drinking problem, or a shopping addiction, or a love of Yoga classes every Tuesday for a half hour longer than you expected. You'll seem to constantly be messing up. You get the silent treatment because you've trained her to know that the moment she removes any validation that you'll step up like a real man and do what she thinks she wants. But it doesn't make her happy. No one likes to play a game where the other person is hell bent on losing.

I'm not a communist, and this isn't critical theory, but we are cavemen with cell phones, and relationships are about power. More importantly, they are about the veneer that power doesn't exist. That's out plausible deniability, and it's what gives women their little dignity. They don't give it though, as benevolence is a male trait. Would it look any different otherwise?

We are in a twisted game that no one seems to know how to play. The dealer has the advantage because of one simple trick, you want to play more than the dealer wants to and so the dealer schemes and cheats and does everything they can in order to get you to stop playing, but you don't and so you point at the deck and pull out a 7 of not getting laid tonight.

Part of it is a fear of abandonment. Guys act terrified (even if they don't think of it that way) to lose a girl. If they forget to be terrified there's always a news story of some guy getting raked over the coals to remind you.



Threatpoint

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Rollo Tomassi calls it the plantation, which is a useful way to understand it. But guys like having a game to play and a dealer to beat. They see it as some nefarious force. They call it feminism, the JQ, or those God Damned Democrats. In reality, it's a million dealers and a million marks playing a rigged game that only exists because we think it has to.

In reality, you, me, every guy has the power. But right now, women are the prize today, not you. They are higher value. Your treatment reflects your standing in the house. This can resentment, hurt, and anger. You have a covert contract in your head, where she is supposed to reciprocate for your gestures. If you play three games she should let you win the fourth, or whatever. Women don't care, they aren't playing fair, and they care less than you do. So you feel that broken and unspoken contract. It hurts. So you lash out, hold grudges and try to communicate your needs and wants. You make women your everything and wonder why they can't be. You can be as objectively right about your grievances as you want, but no one will care if you're in a losing position.

You may get empty promises to shut you up, but no real change. After all, a wife knows what being a good wife means, they just don't want to and you're not the kind of guy who inspires that. If you think I'm talking about oral, or anal, or peace and quiet, I probably am. She's angry because you're needy. You're angry because she's dismissive. You're too emotional. It has to be your fault otherwise the problem is her. Someone sends you the narcissists prayer and you latch onto it like a spider

monkey because what matters now is a convenient excuse and someone else to blame. We have this modern, martyrdom scented narcissism that want to be victim while making identity the only thing that matters. We have become defective women with male sensibilities. We've replaced the delusions of grandeur, aloof attitude and obsessive need to win with playing the victim for sympathy and pretending it makes us noble.

Another 7, better luck next hand.

Guys search everywhere and find a guy, like me, who says they have a solution. Some do, most don't. Most guys offer a different game. They will pull out their own three card Monty except they take your money and tell you what you want to hear:

None of this is your fault. You're doing everything you should be doing. The problem is her. The problem is the system. You're the victim. Your card would have been the queen of hearts. That will be 59.99.

The fact that you sit there playing this game for years communicates low value and desperation. A better man would have left after the first hand. So the more you try to win the more you signal as the mark. Difficult conversations and big life events become burdens and stressors. Maybe if you throw a baby into her it will solve everything. Maybe if you did the dishes more often she would be more comfortable and fuck you more. And when that doesn't happen you get another fight, because she knows:

None of this is your fault. You're doing everything you should be doing. The problem is him. The problem is he doesn't listen.

You're the victim. If you file today you can get a decent payout and find the right man. That will be 59.99.

You can't talk your way into respect and attraction. See how your woman, and other women, treat you when you stop playing this losing bid. Everything we've written about in this space: holding Frame, having Dread, maintaining options (sexually), having boundaries and enforcing them. You know what you want and are willing to do what it takes to get it; which includes ditching the dead weight in your life. It's not easy, it's actually extremely difficult. It requires a ton of work, a lot more introspection and a decent amount of 'fuck it.' Without the introspection you become a delusional child. Without the work you remain a failure. Without the 'fuck it' you'll always care more than she does and never get the power, and with it the desire or admiration, which at the tail end also involves more pussy.



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Of course women are people, and people don't have to indulge in your three card Monty. But like any good dealer you're happy to deal for someone else. That fear of missing out is a superpower. You've become a benevolent dictator. Your game is honest, and when she wins a hand, you win a handy. When you're on this new footing you may not even be dealing with the issues that hurt you so much now. I am always amused when I see a guy whose biggest issue was sexlife, spend a year on his Male Action Plan (MAP) and find a whole new set of issues on the other end. A wife that berates him and doesn't fuck him is horrible, but a wife that fucks him and is in a constant state of neuroticism about losing him is a whole other type of bad. It's a ladder of complaints that always has another rung. Instead of trying to win the game, work on being a better player.

Stop communicating. You will do nothing but sink further by starting a serious conversation or argument from a losing position, no matter how you feel or why. Focus on you and shut the fuck up.

Frame

Dread



For 15 years of men sorting this stuff out for themselves and coming to working solutions, distilled for you to use as you see fit

II.

I struggled with that for years...